

with Sanabassar, and (c) had various prejudices which led them to make deliberate and extensive alterations in the story of Nehemiah. These conclusions each and all present such serious difficulties that, in my opinion, even the view now generally held, with all its absurdities, would be likely to maintain its ground in the face of them.

III. THE NATURE OF FIRST ESDRAS

The main facts regarding the true character of our "apocryphal" Ezra book may be stated briefly as follows: *It is simply a piece taken without change out of the middle of a faithful Greek translation of the Chronicler's History of Israel in the form which was generally recognized as authentic in the last century B. C. This was not, however, the original form of the History, but one which had undergone several important changes.*

As is well known, the apocryphal book and the canonical book are, in the main, merely duplicate versions. But probably many fail to realize how close the duplication is. First Esdras contains a long passage, including chaps. 3, 4, and the first six verses of chap. 5, which is not found in the canonical recension. Aside from this, however, its material contents are exactly those of the corresponding parts of Ezra-Nehemiah. Beginning with the last two chapters of II Chronicles, it then includes the whole of the book of Ezra, and continues with a portion of the Ezra narrative⁵ which is now in our book of Nehemiah, namely, Neh. 8:1-12 and the beginning of the first clause of verse 13, where the fragment ends. In every part of all this history the two recensions generally agree with each other sentence for sentence and clause for clause. In the cases where they fail to agree the differences are due to the usual accidents of manuscript transmission, or to mistakes made by the one or the other translator. The universally accepted view, that First Esdras is a free translation, or a free working-over ("freie Bearbeitung") of the material, is mistaken. The translation is close, and the text as a whole has not been "edited," nor freely handled.

In investigating First Esdras, then, the all-important point of approach is the Story of the Three Youths, which at present stands only in this recension. We need a satisfactory theory of its origin

⁵As I have shown elsewhere, the passage Neh. 7:70-8:18 originally formed a part of the Chronicler's story of Ezra (following Ezra 8), and was accidentally transposed to the place where it now stands. See my *Composition and Historical Value of Ezra-Nehemiah*, pp. 29-34. I shall return to this subject later.